

Q I thought I'd get my stomach back quickly, but it's so wobbly! Will it ever recover?

Your stretched transverse abdominals and uterus mean that your belly won't recover its pre-pregnancy shape immediately. But fear not—the muscles will gradually recover and contract after the birth. The time it takes will be different for each person. Breast-feeding will help speed up the contraction of the uterus, as the hormone oxytocin, which is released when your baby latches on, contracts both the smooth muscles of the milk sacs in your breasts and the smooth muscle cells in your uterus walls.

You can start with some simple exercises to regain your waistline, but you must perform a simple check first on your abdominal muscles (see right). Once you feel a gap of just one finger-width between your transverse abdominals, begin with a simple head and shoulder lift. After your six-week checkup, move on to doing abdominal crunches and sit-ups.

Q How soon is it safe to start having sex after the birth?

Traditional advice recommends no sex until the six-week checkup, although there is no danger to your health if you have sex sooner. When you resume your sex life is a very individual issue, and something you should both take gently. If you feel ready to have sex again as soon as two to three weeks after the birth, that's fine. Penetrative sex may feel a little dry and painful though, so use a lubricant. However, don't feel pressured to resume your sex life until you feel ready. Exhaustion, soreness, and your physical recovery can all take its toll on your libido in the days, weeks, and even months following the birth. Take things slowly with your partner, discuss what you both want, and enjoy kissing and hugging until you are ready for sex. And don't worry if sex feels like it's out of the picture for the foreseeable future: a study conducted by the *British Journal of Obstetrics and Gynaecology* in 2013 found that only 41 percent of first-time mothers had had vaginal intercourse by the time their baby was six weeks old. The most important thing to be aware of is that you are potentially fertile again, even if you are breast-feeding, so take precautions and use contraception.

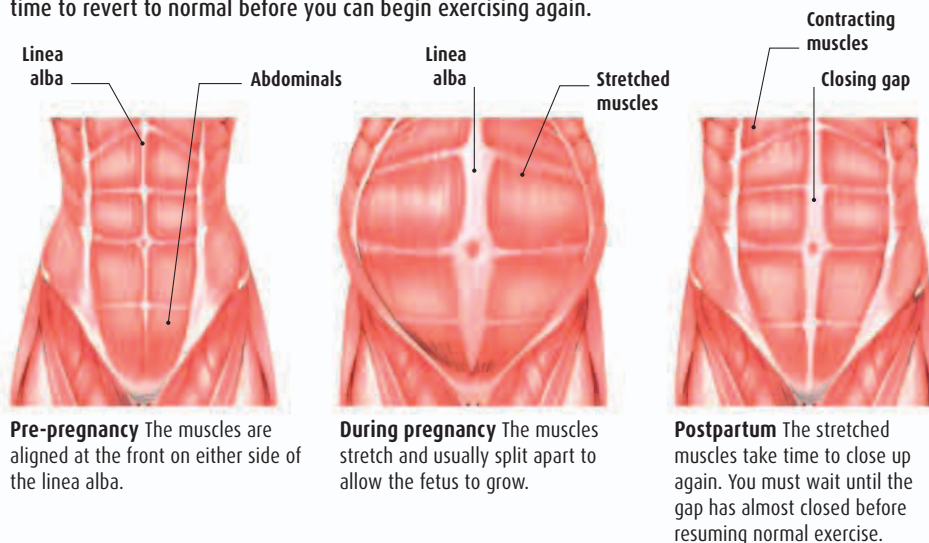
Q How do I get back into shape after the six-week checkup?

Your goal to regain your former level of fitness, or improve your fitness if you were previously quite sedentary, should be gradual, and you shouldn't start high-impact activity too soon. Let your body be your guide.

Once you have the all clear at six weeks, you can build your fitness levels again. However, before you hit the gym in a flurry, do a simple test. Lie on your back, place your hands behind your neck to support it, and slowly lift your head. As you hold that position, place a finger just above your belly button and press down gently to feel the gap between the muscles. If the gap is just one finger-width apart you can start exercising normally; workout moderately for 30 minutes or more a day for three to six months and then gradually work up to high-impact activity. If it is wider—two or more finger-widths apart—don't resume regular exercise yet.

TRANSVERSE ABDOMINAL MUSCLE CHANGES

The natural changes that occur to your muscles in pregnancy need time to revert to normal before you can begin exercising again.



Q I still have a backache. Why hasn't it gone away yet?

You need to continue to protect your back to prevent backaches from bad posture and injury from lifting and carrying. Your loose ligaments, which still haven't tightened up yet, account for some of the pain. But constantly bending down to lift a baby can strain your back muscles. When you pick him or anything else up, bend from your knees, keep your back flat, hold him close to you, and lift up by straightening your legs. Check your posture, too, and keep your back straight and your shoulders back. Ideally your baby should be the heaviest thing you lift for at least the first six weeks after the birth.

In the early weeks after the birth, **resting** when you can and slowing down are two of the most **positive things** you can do, so **don't feel guilty**. Concentrate on your recovery and your baby, exercise gently, eat healthily, and your **energy levels will gradually return**.